

NEWSLETTER

INDUSTRY TALK: SAP COE OPERATIONS



SUMMARY OF THE TALK

In the beginning of the talk, the speaker, Patrick Thong, introduced the history of PPG, a paint and coating company that operates in over 17 countries. PPG currently focuses on automotive industrial coating, packaging and special material manufacturing for passports and licenses. Among its various departments is SAP, which supports the company's operations. PPG is currently converting to the SAP S/4HANA system.

Patrick then explained about SAP, which stands for System Analysis Program Development, an individual application within the SAP ERP system that covers the functional, technical and reporting business domains, and has been in use since 1991. He also introduced ERP (Enterprise Resource Planning Module) as a software system that unifies all activities and provides a single source of truth to help organisations streamline their core business processes such as sales, service and financials.

TECHNOLOGY USED AND CHALLENGES FACED

PPG has been using SAP ERP since 1991, upgrading its system as SAP evolved. PPG Netherlands and Belgium implemented the two-tier R/2 mainframe system for purchasing, stock management, production and MRP, running on the Sigma mainframe.

In 1999, PPG upgraded to R/3, a client-server architecture supporting multiple platforms, which allowed modularisation for specific business functions like finance, HR, and logistics. The SAP Business Warehouse (BW) was also rolled out globally to centralise data.

In 2007, PPG upgraded to SAP ECC 6.0 (Unicode), providing enhanced features and functionality.

Three years after SAP S/4HANA's introduction, PPG implemented it in Australia and New Zealand in 2018, converting non-SAP processes to SAP.

In 2025, PPG launched the "Connect PPG" project to integrate isolated systems across locations. This includes upgrading from SAP ECC 6.0 to SAP S/4HANA for PMC operations in EMEA and APAC, with migration to AWS for improved scalability and performance.

This large and complex project requires careful planning, as varying maturity levels at PPG locations, with some using older versions of SAP and others using Oracle, add to the challenge.

REFLECTION

Goe Jie Ying

The talk helped me understand how SAP operates within PPG and connects to real-world industry practices beyond classroom theory. I also realized that SAP and ERP systems are widely used across industries, which motivates me to keep learning. The session made me look forward to my upcoming internship and encouraged me to prepare for it by improving both my technical and soft skills.

Lam Yoke Yu

From the industry talk, it's clear that systems have evolved significantly, from mainframe computers with one-tier and two-tier architectures to client server architecture and finally cloud-based solutions. The technological landscape is constantly changing which drives the evolution of the system we use. Thus, lifelong learning is indispensable in the field. Besides, we should ensure ourselves to have a wide horizon of knowledge as we would need to implement systems across diverse industries. Having the knowledge can help us to design better systems and can better understand stakeholder needs when analysing system requirements.